



WATCH OUR
REVIEW OF THE
WORLD CUP

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“For the next seven hours, we cut out all the noise. We cut them out of our lives. We create our own bubble here. For seven hours, we step into it, and we finish that game! We write our own story. No more stories from outside. You will write your own stories. Let's create history.”

Head coach Amol Muzumdar's rousing pre-game talk in the huddle set the tone for what would be an epochal triumph for the Indian women's cricket team.

It's been two years since the Mumbai domestic cricket veteran took charge of this women's senior team. Factionalism within the side, a revolving door of coaches, and a general apathy towards professionalism meant fiefdoms thrived in selection and team structure, unsurprisingly impacting success.

For Muzumdar, the mandate was simple. Professionalise the setup, bring in rigour in 'fitness and fielding', and bridge the gap between ambition and its realisation.

The build-up to the tournament was easily the best India has ever had. The Women in Blue played 38 ODIs in this World Cup cycle. In the last 12 months alone, India met Australia twice (once away and once at home), New Zealand, Ireland, and the West Indies at home, and Sri Lanka and South Africa in a tri-series on the island. Players benefited from increased support from the Centre of Excellence. Regular camps were held, one very close to the World Cup in Visakhapatnam, where India would play two key fixtures (against South Africa and Australia).

With more fixtures, an increased focus on fitness and power-hitting thanks to the blooming T20 arm in the women's game, and the competitive impact of the Women's Premier League trickling down to the domestic tier, India's scoring rate also saw a massive jump, with nine of its 13 scores of 300 or more (before the event got underway) coming in just the last two years, a conscious switch in the era

of high-intent cricket.

India also blooded 17 players into the team since December 2023, under Muzumdar, with players ranging from Shreyanka Patil to Kranti Gaud. Only two of them were mainstream batters. Of the 17, Kranti, Shree Charani, and Arundhathi Reddy made it to the World Cup squad.

As the youngsters came in, the senior players also found themselves given more responsibility. Smriti Mandhana became an active part of the strategy team. Jemimah Rodrigues, too, played a role in keeping spirits high and setting a fitness standard the team could emulate.

After years of division and friction, a united front emerged, armed with a seamless chain of command. Surely, it was India's World Cup to lose. Particularly at home.

After a rollercoaster ride of a campaign that saw it stutter more than it should have, India made the summit clash for the third time in the tournament's history. It was the first time England or Australia would not feature in a Women's ODI World Cup final.

Come November 2, the Women in Blue would shut out the testing impatience of a rain delay, a tough opponent in the Proteas, and even a pulsating atmosphere in a packed D.Y. Patil Stadium at times, to finally close out an aching long-standing piece of unfinished business — a conquest of the world.

India started with two victories, against Sri Lanka and Pakistan in Guwahati and Colombo, respectively. The results were as predicted, but the labour needed to secure them wasn't. Though India expected it would coast through against these 'weaker' sides, the host was handed multiple reality checks when its top and middle order faltered. India's lower order had to pick up the pieces of a shattered batting essay and make it competitive.

The issues were basic — a high dot-ball percentage, a tendency to cede control of momentum right after the PowerPlay, and a